Greater understanding with Moscow and Beijing assumes importance for India to realise its broader geopolitical aspirations, including its quest to become a permanent member of the UN Security Council. Moscow's big shift of orienting its economy towards China does not portend well for India, and it may potentially alter the balance of power in Asia, with major implications for India.[42] Even though it is difficult at this stage to gauge the future direction of Russia–China relations, Beijing is certainly taking advantage of Moscow's difficulties. Yet, although Sino–Russian relations are currently at a comfortable level, Russia does have differences on many geopolitical issues with China. This is perhaps one of the reasons Moscow wants India to establish closer ties with Beijing and line up behind the BRI. New Delhi also has an interest in balancing China by deepening its understanding with Moscow, especially when China is going to bolster Pakistan's interest further through the SCO route.

India could use the SCO as a useful means to reboot its relationship with Russia. As India's engagement with United States grows, any prospect of resentment in its relationship with Russia is to be avoided. Russia's pursuit of a divergent foreign policy is evident. Russia has not only pivoted towards China but has also started to cosy up to Pakistan. President Putin, however, has clarified that Russia's proposed arms supply to Pakistan will not impede ties with India.[43] Russia considers Pakistan an important determinant in Afghanistan and believes that engagement with Pakistan will have a positive influence in the Afghanistan–Pakistan region that would serve India's interests, too. India and Russia are committed to strengthening their bilateral strategic partnership agreements. India intends to sign a free trade agreement with the Russian-led Eurasian Economic Union to boost trade and economic ties.[44]